Chapter Four

Agricultural Development Programmes Have Lost Their Purpose

Farmers primarily produce foodgrains, pulses, oilseeds, milk, eggs, meat and the like. Food is the primary need and principal desire of humans. Therefore, it is quite natural for everyone to get emotional about food. Farmers have been elevated to the pedestal of food-givers or annadata.

Farming is a tough enterprise. It is also a highly risky enterprise. Rains may play spoilsport. Other natural calamities—flood, drought, hailstorms—can occur. As there is no invisible market hand playing a balancing role by bringing equilibrium in demand and supply of different agricultural products, prices may crash in the event of overproduction. Farming involves working exposed to the elements in place of the comfort of a factory or office. Finally, as food constitutes a greater part of the consumption expenditure in developing countries like India, governments do not allow farmers to get high prices for their produce. Farming is a low-return enterprise, not a business.

A partial explanation for elevating the farmers in our country to annadata or semi-godly status flows from the self-interest of governments and consumers. Farmers are made to suffer the economic consequences of small and uncertain incomes from their produce as producing food for consumers becomes part of discharging their duty as annadata.

Adam Smith, the father of economics, sought to disabuse both consumers and food-providers of their emotions when he said: ‘It is not from the benevolence of the butcher, the brewer, or the baker that we expect our dinner, but from their regard to their own self-interest. We address